

Dvar Torah Outline — “אָז” as Transcendence, Honor as a Garment, and the Tearing of the Beit HaMikdash’s Splendor (Maharal, ch. 65)

Abstract

Rabbi Shulman continues the Maharal’s discussion (פרק סה) of praising Hashem with the word “אָז,” explaining how “אָז” signals transcendence beyond the natural world of “seven” and even beyond time. He develops the Midrashic image that Israel “clothes” Hashem כביכול with a “חלוק של תפארת,” since honor functions like a garment, and the Torah’s expressions of עֵז are engravings on that robe. Rabbi Shulman then connects the “tearing” of this garment not primarily to the חטא העגל but to the חורבן בית המקדש, when Hashem’s splendor in the lower world is diminished.

I. Framing: continuing Maharal ch. 65 and the Midrash of the “garment of עֵז”

A. The Midrashic image under discussion

- Rabbi Shulman recalls the **מדרש ילקוט שמעוני**: there is a “garment” associated with עֵז and the beautification of Hashem.
- When Israel sins, that garment is described as **torn**; in the future it will be **restored**.

B. The central question

- Why is the praise of Hashem specifically framed with the word “אָז”—as in “אָז וְשִׁיר”—and what does that communicate about Hashem?
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II. “טז” = eight: above the world of seven (0:30)

A. Numerical symbolism

- Rabbi Shulman explains that (**7=ז, 1=א**) טז equals **eight**, symbolizing what is **beyond** the natural order.

B. The “seven” structure of nature

- “Seven” represents the structure of the natural world:
 - **Seven days** of the week.
 - Spatial structure: **six directions** plus a **seventh center point** (cube imagery).

C. The letter א as the “one above” the seven

- :is linked to א
 - אלוה (leader), meaning Hashem as the One who leads and transcends.
 - The theme of אלא (wonder) associated with Hashem’s uniqueness and otherness.
 - Key image: **the א “rides” on top of the ז**—the One above the seven.
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III. “טז” as “then”: not bound to a time-flow (1:00)

A. “Then” as a unique temporal marker

- Rabbi Shulman notes that “טז” means “**then**”, but in a way that:
 - does not clearly indicate past or future,
 - and is not a “continuation” of time.

B. The conceptual point

- Because it is not a tense-bound progression, “טז” suggests something **למעלה מן הזמן** (beyond time).
 - Thus, praising Hashem with “טז” expresses that Hashem is **elevated above** both **nature** and **time**.
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IV. “חלוק של תפארת”: honor as clothing (4:02)

A. Why a “robe” image?

- Rabbi Shulman clarifies that the Maharal’s “חלוק” may not be a highly specific garment-type; it can simply mean a **robe/garment** as a symbol.

B. Clothing as “honor”

- :called his garments רבי יוחנן “מכבודתי” (my honor).
- Rabbi Shulman’s takeaway:
 - If garments are “honor” for a person,
 - then when ישראל accords honor to Hashem, it is described as **clothing** Hashem in honor.

C. Reversibility of the metaphor

- Just as a garment can be called “honor,” **honor can be described as a garment.**
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V. “All the עז in the Torah” engraved on the robe (6:30)

A. What is engraved?

- The Maharal’s claim (as Rabbi Shulman presents it):
 - “ועל זה החלוק היו כתובים כל עז שבתורה”
 - All instances of עז in the Torah point to Hashem’s כבוד.

B. Why עז specifically signals כבוד

- Rabbi Shulman explains:
 - True glory is Hashem being נבדל מהטבע החומרי (separate from physical nature).
 - There is “no greater honor” than being beyond any physical relation or composition.

C. Beauty vs. physical coarseness

- Physicality is described as **opaque/coarse**; it lacks true תפארת.
 - “Beauty” is associated with what appears to **transcend** the muddy, earthy sameness of the material world—therefore עז is an especially fitting term of praise.
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VI. Eight praises vs. fifteen praises: who is speaking, and what that implies (12:30)

A. The “eight praises” are framed as uttered by the lower beings

- Rabbi Shulman notes the Maharal’s point:
 - these praises are described as coming from **”הבריות שבתחתונים”**—created beings below (Israel / the righteous / creation).

B. Contrast: the fifteen praises of **”ישתבח”**

- In **ישתבח**, the liturgy says:
 - **”כִּי לָךְ ה' אֱלֹהֵינוּ שִׁיר וְשִׁבְחָה הִלֵּל וְזִמְרָה עֹז וּמִשְׁלָה...”**
(For Yours, Hashem our God, are song and praise, acclaim and melody, might and dominion...)
- Rabbi Shulman emphasizes:
 - It is not “they will say” about Hashem,
 - but rather stated as direct attribution: **”לָךְ”**—to You.

C. Conceptual difference

- The “eight” praises highlight how the lower world recognizes Hashem’s transcendence over the world they inhabit.
 - presents praise as direct description of Hashem (less about the **”ישתבח”** speakers, more about the truth being stated).
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VII. Miracles and **”אֲזַ”**: the right praise for what is above nature (16:42)

A. Why **”אֲזַ”** appears at moments of salvation

- Rabbi Shulman summarizes the Maharal:
 - **A נס** is **למעלה מן הטבע** (above nature).
 - Therefore, after a miracle it is fitting to praise Hashem with **”אֲזַ”**, which itself signifies transcendence.

B. “Lower beings” clothing Hashem with splendor

- Because the miracle elicits recognition from below, Israel “clothes” Hashem כביכול with the חלוק של תפארת through this mode of praise.
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VIII. The torn garment: not (only) the Golden Calf, but the Churban (18:12)

A. Addressing a timeline difficulty

- Rabbi Shulman notes an issue raised in discussion:
 - Some “אָז” praises being cited appear in **later** sections of Tanach (נביאים/כתובים), which complicates tying the tearing solely to חטא העגל.

B. Reframing the “tearing” as Churban-centered

- Rabbi Shulman explains the Maharal’s conclusion:
 - The “torn robe” more plausibly corresponds to חורבן בית המקדש.
 - With the Mikdash destroyed, there is diminished כבוד ותפארת בתחתונים—Hashem’s splendor manifest in the lower world is reduced.

C. The Mikdash as the core “תפארת” from below

- The Beit HaMikdash is identified as the prime expression of the world’s honor given to Hashem.
- When that is destroyed, it is described as:
 - “חלוק של תפארת... קרוע”—the garment of splendor is torn.

D. Connecting to the language of “אמר/האמיר”

- Rabbi Shulman links the Maharal’s reading to the verse-type language:
 - “אַתָּה הָאֵל הַמְאֲמִיר... וְהָאֵל הַמְאֲמִיר” (You have uplifted/beautified Hashem... and Hashem has uplifted you)
 - The “beautification” relationship is damaged when the Mikdash—the central locus of that beautification—is lost.
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IX. A brief Kabbalistic aside: תפארת as the “central point” (22:32)

- Rabbi Shulman briefly gestures to how one might frame תפארת in the language of ספירות:
 - תפארת as a central unifying point among the מידות,
 - with Hashem’s Name hinting to the structure (י-ה-ו-ה).
 - He cautions against getting lost in technicalities, suggesting the Maharal’s style as a safer entry point because it conveys concepts from multiple angles without requiring dense systemization.
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X. In Summary

- Rabbi Shulman explains that praising Hashem with “אָז” expresses Hashem’s transcendence: **eight beyond seven**, and beyond ordinary **time-flow**.
- Israel’s praise “clothes” Hashem כביכול in a **חלוק של תפארת**, because **honor functions like a garment**.
- The Torah’s expressions of עֵץ signify Hashem’s unique כבוד as beyond physical nature, and thus belong engraved on that “robe.”
- The garment’s “tearing” is best understood as reflecting **חורבן בית המקדש**, when Hashem’s splendor manifest in the lower world is profoundly diminished.